

Final Assignment R5B Spring 2026

In this course, we have read translated Mughal-era texts—chronicles, travel writings, autobiographical writings, and courtly narratives. These works were not simply records of events; they were carefully composed texts shaped by audience, power, religion, social position, and purpose. Mughal writers paid close attention to how they presented themselves, whom they addressed, and why they were writing.

For the final assignment, you will write your own text as a “primary source,” using the structure and rhetorical conventions of Mughal writing while describing your own life and experiences. You are not pretending to be a Mughal-era person. You will write as yourself, but you will consciously use Mughal writing conventions to frame your narrative.

Your text must be written in the first person and should begin with a formal opening. To see what this looks like, consider how Jahangir opens his *Tuzuk*: he invokes God, establishes his identity, and explains the purpose of his memoir. Badauni opens his *Muntakhab al-Tawarikh* by positioning himself as a servant of truth and framing his chronicle as a corrective to flattering court histories. In both cases, the opening tells the reader who is speaking, under whose authority, and why this text exists. Your opening must include an invocation (to God, fate, knowledge, justice, time, truth, or another guiding principle), a brief acknowledgment of an authority or institution that shapes your life (Berkeley, your workplace, your family, your hometown), and a logic explaining why this text is being written. To show that this is possible in contemporary language, here is an example (not a template to copy, but proof of concept): ***“In the name of knowledge, which orders all things and without which no record has value, I set down this account of my years at this university, so that something of what it meant to be a student in this city at this time might be preserved and understood.”***

You should then describe who you are by explaining your social position and identity—your roles as a student, worker, family member, or citizen, and the forms of support or limitation that structure your life. Think about how Banarasidas describes himself not just as an individual but as a member of a caste, a family, and a mercantile network. Your identity is relational too!

Your essay should also explore how power operates in your daily life—who holds authority over you, where your agency is limited or enabled, and how rules, expectations, or institutions shape your actions. Mughal writers often discussed power indirectly rather than making direct claims. Notice how Badauni conveys disapproval of Akbar not through accusation but through tone, selection of detail, and careful irony. You are not required to be that subtle, but you should be aware that how you say something is itself a rhetorical choice.

Finally, describe aspects of culture and everyday life by focusing on routines, habits, and the spaces you move through. The distinction between a routine and a culturally meaningful practice matters here. Getting coffee every morning is a routine. But if getting coffee is about performing a particular student identity, navigating a social hierarchy, or managing anxiety about academic performance in ways that reveal how this institution structures your relationship to your own mind, then it becomes

culturally meaningful and worth writing about. The test is not what you do but what 'the doing' means. Try to make this section a composite of ethics, morals, and socio-cultural observation that registers your everydayness as a university student.

Throughout, maintain a thoughtful and controlled tone and avoid slang or overly casual language. You do not need to imitate archaic vocabulary; writing clearly and precisely in contemporary English is appropriate. A practical test: read your draft aloud. If it sounds like a text message, revise it upward. If it sounds like an impersonal essay with no narrator, revise in the other direction.

At the end, add a brief reflective postscript of 150-200 words in which you step outside the exercise. Why did you choose that guiding principle? What did you decide to omit, and why? What did writing in this form reveal about how Mughal writers constructed their texts and what they were performing, concealing, or claiming?

The primary text should be approximately 1000-1200 words. The postscript should be 150-200 words.